

Polyvibe

A lamp-and-photocell vibe: four unequal phase stages swept by a modelled light bulb, with a preamp for colour.



Overview

Polyvibe is a vibe effect in the spirit of the classic lamp-and-photocell units. Four unequal phase-shift stages are swept by a light bulb shining on light-dependent resistors. The bulb heats up quickly and cools slowly, and the photocells lag behind it, so the sweep is lopsided - the familiar throbbing, liquid swirl rather than an even phaser.

In CHORUS mode the shifted signal is mixed with the dry one for the classic swirl; in VIBRATO mode you hear only the shifted signal, which gives a pitch wobble. A transistor-style preamp runs in every mode, adding asymmetric saturation, a low-mid lift and a rounded top - and PREAMP mode switches the vibe off so you can use the preamp on its own.

Reach for it for

- The classic swirling vibe on clean or driven guitar
- Organ and electric piano that needs slow, throbbing movement
- Pitch-wobble vibrato on vocals, guitars and synths
- Wide stereo movement with SPREAD
- Warm preamp colour on its own (PREAMP mode)

Controls

Modes (header)

CHORUS	The dry signal plus the phase-shifted one, half and half: the classic vibe swirl, with moving notches in the response.
VIBRATO	The phase-shifted signal only. The response stays flat and you hear a pitch wobble.
PREAMP	The vibe is off; only the preamp colours the sound. The lamp shows LAMP OFF.

The display

Lamp	The glowing orb shows the bulb's brightness as it pulses, with L and R bars beside it for each channel (they differ when SPREAD is up).
Response	In CHORUS mode, the live frequency response with the current notch frequency shown above it. In VIBRATO mode the response is flat.

Rate mode

FREE	SPEED is set in Hz.
SYNC	SPEED is a note value locked to the project tempo and timeline, so the sweep lines up with the bars and follows loop jumps.
FLOW	Tempo-synced, but the sweep runs continuously through loops and restarts.

Preamp

AMOUNT	The preamp colour, 0 - 100% (starts at 40%). It adds asymmetric saturation, lifts the low mids and rounds off the top. The word beside the knob shows the character: clean,
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warm, pushed or driven. At 0% the preamp is clean. Works in every mode.

Vibe

SPEED	How fast the lamp pulses: 0.1 - 12 Hz in FREE, or a note value from 4 BARS to 1/32 (with dotted and triplet values) in SYNC and FLOW.
INTENSITY	How far the sweep travels, 0 - 100%. Low settings are subtle; high settings are deep and swirling.
THROB	How much of the bulb's lopsided character you hear, 0 - 100%. At 0% the sweep follows a smooth sine; turned up, the fast-heat, slow-cool lamp and lagging photocells give the uneven, pulsing throb.
SPREAD	Offsets the right channel's sweep from the left, 0 - 180 degrees. 0 is mono movement; higher settings make the vibe move across the stereo field.

Drift

A slow random wander, like an old lamp and tired components. DRIFT (0 - 100%, starting at 50%) sets how much: 50% is the standard amount, 100% twice that, 0% none. In Polyvibe it moves three things: the speed (in FREE the rate wanders; in SYNC and FLOW the sweep wobbles but stays locked on average), the intensity (the sweep gets a little shallower at times) and the lamp brightness (the bulb dims a little). The wander also speeds up a little as DRIFT goes up.

IN / OUT

TRIM	Input level before anything else, from -24 to +12 dB.
GUARD	Click the TRIM knob (without moving it) to switch the guard; its light sits at the knob's upper right. On by default. Gently eases very hot sources down towards about -18 dBFS average and catches fast peaks above -6 dBFS, so loud sources never overdrive the plugin. It never boosts

	quiet sources. The light glows brighter while it is catching peaks.
SAT	Band saturation on the way out: only the lows and highs are saturated (the mids stay clean), with a soft curve that loosens as the level rises.

Master

MIX	Blends the untreated input back in, 0 - 100%. At 100% you hear only the effect (which, in CHORUS mode, already contains the dry signal).
OUTPUT	Output level, -24 to +12 dB.
Meters	Output level, left and right.

The header

PRESETS	Opens the list of factory presets; the ◀ / ▶ keys step through them and the display shows the one in use. Choosing one sets the mode, rate, vibe, preamp, MIX and drift settings; the DRIFT dial, OUTPUT and the IN / OUT controls are left as they are. The last entry resets everything to the defaults.
S / M / L	Panel size: small, medium or large. The panel also scales to fit the plugin window.
?	Opens a pop-up with the design credit, the GFX website address and the address of this manual. Click anywhere to close it.

Presets

Classic Chorus	The everyday vibe swirl: CHORUS at 2 Hz, 70% intensity and throb.
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Slow Throb	A slow, deep CHORUS (0.6 Hz) with strong throb and a little more lamp drift.
Fast Swirl	A quick CHORUS at 6.5 Hz, a little less deep.
Vibrato	VIBRATO mode at 4.5 Hz for a pitch wobble, with a lighter preamp.
Stereo Vibe	CHORUS at 1.5 Hz with the right side offset by 90 degrees.
Synced 1/8	CHORUS locked to eighth notes of the project tempo.
Preamp Only (Clean)	The vibe off, with a light preamp colour.
Preamp Only (Pushed)	The vibe off, with the preamp at 80%.
Ageing Lamp	A slow, throbbing CHORUS with lots of drift on the speed, depth and lamp - an old, unsteady unit.
Reset all to defaults	Every control back to its starting value.

Tips

- For the classic guitar vibe, start with Classic Chorus and set SPEED by ear to the tempo of the song; turn THROB up for more of the pulsing character.
- Put Polyvibe before a drive or amp for a thick, chewy swirl; after it for a cleaner, more open sound.
- VIBRATO with a low INTENSITY gives a gentle, tape-like wobble on vocals and keys.
- On a mono source, a SPREAD of 90 degrees or more makes the movement swirl across the speakers.

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